

The job is finding a photo you still picture — not a better search box

People start with a fragment of memory. Success is opening the photo they meant. Faster indexing or a smarter keyword rank is a different product.

North-star metric • PRODUCT BET

Successful vague-memory retrieval rate = users who find the intended photo on a vague-memory task ÷ users who start a search with incomplete memory.

Out of scope

Search latency, ranking of exact keywords, and "make search feel faster."

- METRIC DECOMPOSITION

That number only moves if Photos understands the clue the person still has

One bet. The other steps stay healthy; they are not a second product.

Formulate

Turn incomplete memory into a starting clue.

Understand · PRODUCT BET

Accept vibe, object, or episode — not a date first.

Retrieve

Target in the first grouped set.

Recognize

The person opens the intended photo.

Refine

"More like this" or "not this trip."

Sub-metrics: formulation rate, clue-understanding rate, candidate coverage, recognition rate, refinement success, workaround-scroll rate, known-item control success.

Public voice becomes ranked retrieval problems — not a sentiment dashboard

1

Listen

Public photo talk:
stores, forums,
community posts.

2

Keep

Stories about a
failed find. Drop
storage and star-
rating noise.

3

Group

Themes that
share at least two
real quotes.

4

Score

Impact,
feasibility, and
how often it
appears.

5

Drop

"Search is slow" is
not this job.

Research covered: photo kinds people struggle to find, remembered vs forgotten cues, search breakdowns, workarounds, result quality, refinement behavior, and segment differences.

• OPPORTUNITY RANKING

Place without a name is the first problem we will solve.
Generic search we refused.

People remember how a café felt and have forgotten the town.

Opportunity	Impact	Feasibility	Frequency	Node
Place-vibe without name	High	High	High	Understand
Generic search latency	High	High	High	Out of scope
Object + episode	Medium	Medium	Medium	Understand

Top opportunity: place-vibe without a name · Metric: understand · Audience: trip rememberers

Six trip rememberers validated the hypothesis before we built

Method

Google Form questionnaire and 30-minute conversation.
Reconstruct one failed photo search until the memory is specific.

Screener

Uses Photos for at least a year, has a substantial library, and can recall a photo they remember but have not been able to find.

Protocol

Recover: retrieval task, remembered cues, forgotten cues, query typed, Photos response, workaround, recognizability, next attempt.

[View the research questionnaire](#) · All six respondents met the audience criteria; known-item searches were excluded.

• WHAT THE RESEARCH CONFIRMED

Place-vibe confirmed. Forgotten date/album confirmed. Generic search not supported.

Discovery theme	Finding	Product implication
Place-vibe without name	Confirmed	People recalled how a place felt on a trip even when they had forgotten the town.
Forgotten date/album	Confirmed	People remembered the photo without its date or album. The product bet remains understanding the clue.
Timeline scroll workaround	Confirmed	People scrolled, asked someone, tried another app, or gave up.
Generic search latency	Not supported	The study asked about retrieval from memory, not search speed; latency remains out of scope.

The study did not capture result grids or exact library sizes. No first-person quotes were invented; public discovery quotes remain labeled as public voice.

- THE PROBLEM

People remember how a place felt on a trip and have forgotten the date, album, and town name

Target segment

Trip rememberers with large photo libraries. They recall a trip by its atmosphere, activity, or objects but have forgotten the date, album, or town.

Retrieval scenario

The café I cannot date — a trip photo the person can still picture when capture day and place name are gone.

Product outcome · PRODUCT BET

Understand — the product accepts vibe, object, episode, and fuzzy time. Exactly one node.

Root cause: Search cannot use the clue that remains, even though the photo is in the library. People scroll, ask someone, try another app, or give up. Business risk: a library people cannot re-enter becomes a write-only backup.

- REMEMBER

Remember puts intelligence at the moment of understanding: a vibe in, a trip group out

1

Offer a fragment

Type or speak what is left. Never a date first.

2

See a trip group

Photos groups the trip and says why this set.

3

Confirm or steer

Open the photo, or say "not this trip."

Keyword Search stays the control. Remember is a different path — not a second search box. Intelligence at understand (place-vibe language → grouped candidates).

- RETURN TEST RESULTS

Three return sessions found the café, the trip, and the gig. Keep grouping by trip.

What worked (three return sessions)

In each session, keyword search missed and Remember found the intended photo: a café on a Goa trip, a Goa trip photo, and a concert remembered by its lights.

What to change next · PRODUCT BET

Keep trip grouping with near-miss Europe café. Place-name clue still has to group by trip. Keep vibe-language grouping (lights/gig) and never ask venue or date first.

Three trip rememberers completed retrieval tasks, tried the keyword baseline, and identified a next change. These results use a prototype library, not participants' Google Photos accounts.

- SUCCESS METRICS & RISKS

We will know it worked when more of these searches end on the right photo

Leading metrics

- Clue submitted as memory language (without date first)
- Remember accepts place, object, activity, and approximate-time clues
- Intended photo appears in the first grouped set
- Intended photo opened from a group
- Successful find after refining

Risks & mitigations

- Read as "better search" → composer asks for fragment, not "Search your photos"
- Model invents a date or town → ground interpretation in the user's words and reject invented dates or location metadata
- Learned café task success → use a respondent's own task when the original photo can be used

Guardrails: a known-date task should still succeed in Search; the system must not invent capture dates or location metadata. Metrics are prototype signals, not Google Photos production telemetry.

Three risks, each with a mitigation